This Hurts from Almost, Maine

By John Cariani

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *There is the love we find or fall into, the love we're looking for or hoping for or, alternately, trying like hell to avoid.*

ACTOR: *And there is the love we embrace, the love that dies quickly or slowly, the love we walked away from years earlier – thus, the love that's stand-in for anything and everything we ever wanted but never was ours.*

ACTRESS: *As the song on that TV commercial says, love hurts. Even for a young man who can't feel any pain.*

ACTOR: *With dark echoes of the Garden of Eden, love enters this man's life unexpectedly in his apartment laundry room – but at the same moment, so does pain.*

TOGETHER: *This Hurts from Almost, Maine by John Cariani*

Lights come up on a woman finishing up ironing a man's clothes, in the laundry room of Ma Dudley's Boarding House in Almost, Maine. A man is sitting on a bench. The woman starts folding the man's shirt she was ironing, but thinks better of it, and instead, deliberately crumples it, and throws it into her laundry basket. She picks up the iron, wraps the cord around it, preparing to put it away. As she does so, she burns herself on it.

WOMAN: Ow! Dammit! *(The man takes note of this and writes "iron" in a homemade book labeled "Things That Can Hurt You." Meanwhile, the woman has exited to return the iron to its proper place. She returns to deal with the ironing board, which also must be returned to its proper place —the same place she just brought the iron. After folding up the ironing board, she turns to exit and accidentally wallops the man in the head with the ironing board, knocking him off the bench he was sitting on.)* Oh, no! I'm sorry! I'm sorry! Oh ... I didn't see you, are you okay?!?

MAN: (Unfazed.) Yes

WOMAN: No you're not!! I smashed you with the ironing board, I wasn't even looking! Are you hurt?

MAN: No.

WOMAN: Oh, you must be!! I just smashed you! Where did I get you?

MAN: In the head.

WOMAN: In the head!?! Oh, (Going to him.) come here, are you okay?

MAN: Is there any blood?

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WOMAN: No.

MAN: Any discoloration?

WOMAN: No.

MAN: Then I'm okay.

WOMAN: Well, I'm gonna go get you some ice.

MAN: No. I can't feel things like that.

WOMAN: Like what?

MAN: Like when I get smashed in the head with an ironing board. I don't get hurt.

WOMAN: What?

MAN: I can't feel pain.

WOMAN: Oh, Jeezum Crow (Say, "JEE-zum CROW"— it's euphemism.), what have I done to you?

MAN: Nothin'—-

WOMAN: You're talkin' loopy, listen to you, goin' on about not being able to feel pain, that's delusional, I've knocked the sense right outta ya!

MAN: No, I'm okay.

WOMAN: Shh! Listen: I was gonna be a nurse, so I know: You're hurt. You just took a good shot right to the head, and that's serious.

MAN: No, it's not serious. I don't think an ironing board could really hurt your head, 'cause, see, (Forcing his "Things That Can Hurt You" book on her.) ironing boards aren't on my list of things that can hurt you,

WOMAN: (Dealing with his book.) What is — ?

MAN: plus, there's no blood or discoloration from where I got hit, so ...

WOMAN: Well, you can be hurt and not be bleeding or bruised —

MAN: And my list is pretty reliable, 'cause my brother Paul is helping me make it, and I can prove it to you: See, I bet if I took this ironing board, like this,

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and hit you with it, that it wouldn't hurt you (He smashes her in the head with the ironing board.), see?, that didn't hurt.

WOMAN: OW!! (Scrambling to get away from him.)

MAN: Oh!

WOMAN: Ow! What the hell was that?! // Why did you do that?

MAN: Oh! I'm sorry. Did that hurt?

WOMAN: God!

MAN: Oh, it did, didn't it?

WOMAN: Ow!

MAN: Oh, I didn't think it would 'cause, see, ironing boards are not on my list of things that can hurt you, but, gosh, maybe they should be on my list, because —

WOMAN: What are you talkin' about?

MAN: I have a list of things that can hurt you, my brother Paul is helping me make it, and ironing boards aren't on it.

WOMAN: Well, that ironing board hurt me.

MAN: Yeah.

WOMAN: So you should add it to your list.

MAN: Yeah. (Beat. He adds "ironing boards" to his list of "Things That Can Hurt You." He then picks up a book labeled "Things to Be Afraid Of.") Should I be afraid of ironing boards?

WOMAN: Well, if someone swings it at your head and wallops you with it, yes ...

MAN: Well, it's not — I have a list of things to be afraid of, too — and ironing boards are not on this list either.

WOMAN: Well they shouldn't be, really.

MAN: No?

WOMAN: No, you shouldn't be afraid of ironing boards.

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MAN: No?

WOMAN: No.

MAN: But they can hurt you.

WOMAN: Yeah.

MAN: So I should be afraid of them.

WOMAN: No.

MAN: So I shouldn't be afraid of them?

WOMAN: Right.

MAN: But they can hurt me.

WOMAN: Well, if they're used the way you used it, yeah.

MAN: Oh-oh-oh! So, they're kind of like the opposite of God!

WOMAN: What?

MAN: Well, ironing boards can hurt me, but I shouldn't be afraid of them, but God, my brother Paul says, God won't hurt me, but I should fear him.

WOMAN: I guess.

MAN: Boy, this is getting very complicated.

WOMAN: What is?

MAN: This business of learning what hurts, what doesn't hurt, what to be afraid of, what not to be afraid of.

WOMAN: Are you sure you're okay? You're just goin' on and on about crazy stuff —

MAN: Oh, yeah, yeah, see, I have congenital analgesia, he thinks. Some // people —

WOMAN: What?

MAN: Congenital analgesia.

WOMAN: Who thinks?

MAN: My brother Paul. Some people call it hereditary sensory neuropathy type four, but ... it just means I can't feel pain. You can hit me if you want to, to see!

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WOMAN: No.

MAN: Go ahead. It won't hurt. See? (He hits his head with the book. Composition books work pretty well, because they make a great sound and don't actually hurt!)

WOMAN: OW!

MAN: See? (He hits his head again.)

WOMAN: OW!

MAN: See? (Hits his head again.)

WOMAN: OW!

MAN: Go ahead. (He offers her the book labeled "Things That Can Hurt You"so she can hit him with it.)

WOMAN: No!

MAN: Come on!

WOMAN: No!!

MAN: Come on !

WOMAN: NO!!

MAN: Okay. You don't have to. Most people don't. Hit me. Most people just go away. You can go away, too, if you want to. That's what most people do when I tell them about myself. My brother Paul says I just shouldn't tell people about myself, because I scare them, (Referring to his book labeled "Things to Be Afraid Of" so he can show her.) so I've actually recently put "myself" on my list of things to be afraid of, but — (Her curiosity getting the better of her, the woman comes up from behind the man and wallops him on the back of the head with the book labeled "Things That Can Hurt You. ")

WOMAN: Oh, my gosh! I'm sorry! Oh, my gosh! I just clocked you!

MAN: You hit me! Most people go away, but you hit me!

WOMAN: I had to see [what would happen]! But — are you okay?

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MAN: Yeah, I don't feel pain!

WOMAN: ... Don't feel pain, right, of course you're okay! — But — are you sure?

MAN: Well, is there any blood?

WOMAN: No.

MAN: Any discoloration?

WOMAN: No.

MAN: Then I'm okay.

WOMAN: Well, buddy, you can be hurt and not even look like it.

MAN: But —

WOMAN: Trust me. There are things that hurt you that make you bruised and bloody and there are things that hurt you that don't make you bruised and bloody and ... they all hurt. (Beat. Then, giving him back the book labeled "Things That Can Hurt You":) I'm Marvalyn.

MAN: I'm Steve. I live on the third floor. Room Eleven.

MARVALYN: (Deflecting.) I live with my boyfriend, Eric. I love him very much.

STEVE: Yeah. We saw you move in.

MARVALYN: Yeah. Our roof collapsed from all the snow in December. We're just here until we can get our feet back on the ground.

STEVE: Oh. Well, that's good, 'cause that's what Ma Dudley says her boarding house is. A place where people can live until they get their feet back on the ground. My brother Paul says we've been trying to get our feet back on the ground our whole lives.

MARVALYN: Oh.

STEVE: Yeah, it takes some people longer to do that than others.

MARVALYN: Yeah. (Beat.)

STEVE: You guys are loud.

MARVALYN: Huh?

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STEVE: You and Eric. You yell and bang. We're right below you.

MARVALYN: Oh. Sorry about that. We're goin' through a rough patch. Happens. Sorry. (Beat. Then, changing the subject:) What is it like?

STEVE: What?

MARVALYN: To not feel pain.

STEVE: I don't know. I don't know what it's like to hurt, so ... I don't know. I don't really feel.

MARVALYN: Is this ... how you were born?

STEVE: Yeah. I don't have fully developed pain sensors. They're immature, my brother Paul says //, and because they're immature —

MARVALYN: How does he know that?

STEVE: Oh, he reads,

MARVALYN: But —

STEVE: and because they're immature, my development as a human being has been retarded, he says,

MARVALYN: But —

STEVE: but he teaches me what hurts, though.

MARVALYN: Why??

STEVE: So I won't ruin myself. I have to know what hurts, so I know when to be afraid. See, my mind can't tell me when to be afraid, 'cause my body doesn't know what being hurt is, so I have to memorize what might hurt.

MARVALYN: Okay...

STEVE: And I have to memorize what to be afraid of. (Showing her, in his book.) Things like bears. And guns and knives. And fire. And fear — I should fear fear itself— and pretty girls ...

MARVALYN: Pretty girls?

STEVE: (He thinks she's pretty.) Yeah.

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MARVALYN: Why should you be afraid of pretty girls?

STEVE: Well, 'cause my brother Paul says they can hurt you 'cause they make you love them, and that's something I'm supposed to be afraid of, too — love — but Paul says that I'm really lucky, 'cause I'll probably never have to deal with love, because I have a lot of deficiencies and not very many capacities as a result of the congenital analgesia.

MARVALYN: Wait, what do you mean you're never gonna have to deal with love //, why —

STEVE: 'Cause I'm never gonna know what it feels like, Paul says.

MARVALYN: Well, how does he know that?

STEVE: 'Cause it hurts.

MARVALYN: It shouldn't.

STEVE: And, plus, I have a lot of deficiencies and not very many capacities.

MARVALYN: You know what, a lot of people do. (She kisses him. At first it's just Marvalyn kissing Steve, but, eventually, Steve participates. Then Marvalyn breaks away.) I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. Are you all right? Are you okay?

STEVE: (Doesn't quite know how to respond. He hasn't learned about this. Then, maybe feeling his lips, and resorting to his usual way of answering this question.) Well ... is there any blood?

MARVALYN: No .

STEVE: Any discoloration?

MARVALYN: No.

STEVE: Then I'm all right. (Is he?)

MARVALYN: Yeah. You are. (Beat.) I'm so sorry I did that. It's just— ... You're just very sweet.

STEVE: (Trying to make sense of what just happened.) But ... you have a boyfriend and you love him very much.

MARVALYN: (She begins gathering her stuff.) Yes I do. And yes I do.

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STEVE: And you just kissed me.

MARVALYN: Yes I did.

STEVE: And it's Friday night and you're doing your laundry.

MARVALYN: Yes I am.

STEVE: And people who are in love with each other, they don't kiss other people and do their laundry on Friday nights, I've learned that. People who are in love with each other, they go to The Moose Paddy on Friday nights, or they go dancing together, or they go skating. And they kiss each other. They don't kiss other people — you know what? I don't think that's love, // what you and your boyfriend have —

MARVALYN: (Deflecting, preparing to leave.) I've been down here longer than I said I would be and he doesn't like that.

STEVE: Who?

MARVALYN: My boyfriend.

STEVE: Who you love very much.

MARVALYN: Yes.

STEVE: Even though you kissed me?

MARVALYN: Yes.

STEVE: Wow, I'm going to have to talk to my brother Paul about this —

MARVALYN: No! Don't talk to your brother Paul about this! Tell him to stop teaching you.

STEVE: What?

MARVALYN: Whatever he's teaching you. Tell him to stop. What he's teaching you ... isn't something you wanna know.

STEVE: But I have to learn from him —

MARVALYN: Look: I was gonna be a nurse, so I know: You need to go to a doctor, and not have your brother read whatever it is he reads.

STEVE: But —

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MARVALYN: You know what, I gotta go.

STEVE: (Sits down on the bench.) Right. You gotta go. You're—you're leaving. I knew you would. That's what people do.

MARVALYN: No, I just have to — .1 told you, Eric // doesn't like it if—I

STEVE: Your boyfriend?

MARVALYN: Yeah, he doesn't like it if I'm down here longer than f. I said I'd be, and I've been down here longer than I said I'd be —(On this line, Marvalyn picks up the ironing board. Then, as she goes to put it away, she accidentally swings it around and hits Steve in the head, just as she did at the beginning of the scene. Steve gets knocked off the bench.)

STEVE: OW!

MARVALYN: Oh! I'm so sorry!

STEVE: OW!

MARVALYN: I'm so sorry!, are you all right? I can't believe I just did that to you again! \

STEVE: OW!!

MARVALYN: (She goes to help him; stops short.) Wait — : What did you just say?

STEVE: (As he rubs his head, he realizes what he just said. Beat. He looks at Marvalyn, tells her plainly:) Ow. (Music. Marvalyn and Steve just look at each other. Utter uncertainty. This is scary. And wonderful. But mostly a little scary — because who knows what's next. Lights fade.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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